discount them. That leaves the Indian media as the single-largest barrier between a healthy narrative about Pakistan and Pakistanis. This is not a sweeping statement. There are some brilliant writers, reporters and commentators in the Indian press. And no, I'm not just picking on one country's media here: Pakistani media has got its own issues brewing. Sure, a free press is good for the country. But since the television ratings game has been unleashed, South Asian media has held itself hostage.

I must admit I'm addicted to the news. But news channels nowadays are more like movie channels. There's a lot of acting. There's a lot of overacting. There's a lot of lying. You can see the script unfold, live on prime-time television. Even though the press is crucial for the country, journalists forget that they need to be a source of inspiration, not desperation. Seemingly, most anchors and reporters are not educated and that clearly shows. They are barely ethical, too, and that shows as well. I understand the concept of breaking news. But not the concept of breaking the country or the sport or hearts. They play God, these mediawalas. This insanity has to stop.

On a side note, the BCCI needs to warm things up a bit, too, media- and outreach-wise. Whenever we have toured India, we've been very open and proactive. We give the Indian media tons of access and interviews – too bad that Indian players who've toured Pakistan have never really reciprocated.

That last tour in 2016 to India really split things open. It left a bitter taste in my mouth – the whole team's, perhaps. The security concerns didn't help. The media hype only compounded the tension. A lot of the new guys on the tour were worried, and stress worked its way into their game. But the crowds loved us. India's crowds are awesome. Possibly the most awesome on the planet. Too bad they can't elect a government that is good to them.

I have a complaint to file in India. Not the Indian people, whom I love for their support, nor the Indian team, which stands as one of the finest in the world. My complaint is to the Indian government. So here goes:

If anybody from the Indian government reads this, I hope they realize that it's not just me who thinks that what has happened to this great India–Pakistan cricket rivalry is very unfortunate. I simply don't understand what the Indian government is up to when it comes to not letting these two teams engage on the cricket field. They need to let us play more cricket with each other. Either the good people in New Delhi don't understand the true cricketing value of an India versus Pakistan match, or they don't understand that sport is actually a great mechanism for building ties and breaking down barriers. I feel that the Indian government should show some flexibility, even some sensitivity, to the hopes and aspirations of the millions – no, billions – in the subcontinent, who want India and Pakistan to play more cricket.

Also, I'm not overestimating when I say that in today's day and age, an India–Pakistan clash is bigger than the Ashes. If there is a regular, annual series, I can predict that maybe, even the World Cup will be challenged in terms of importance to the sponsors and TV channels. It's essential that we play together and more often. It's also essential for the financial future of the game.

As for the state of the contemporary game, it's unfortunate for Pakistan that the balance of the India–Pak rivalry has now tipped in India's favour. Since the likes of Yuvraj Singh, Gautam Gambhir, M.S. Dhoni and Suresh Raina came into the game, the new generation of players has pushed the old guard aside. India's fresh blood, like Virat Kohli, have really brought new life into